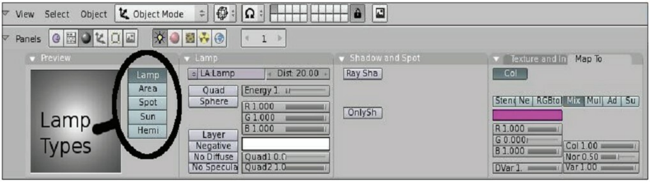

Figure 3: Lamp types

innovations concerning meshes and vertices in the latest versions of Blender.

In Blender 2.49b, after creating a mesh, we can go straight into Edit mode to edit its vertices. In Edit mode, selected vertices are highlighted in yellow dots, while unselected ones are shown in pink dots. In order to select a vertex, you need to right-click on it.

Every object created in Blender 2.49b bears a small dot (generally in its centre) which is called the object's centre. Since the centre does not always move under Edit mode, it is advisable to switch to Object mode before moving objects. If you need to relocate an object's centre, simply press 'Centre Cursor' under Edit buttons.

Viewport shading

In Blender 2.49b and 2.50 Alpha, the viewport is set to solid shading by default. However, only visible vertices can be selected in solid shading. To switch to wireframe mode, where all vertices can be selected, press the 'Z' key.

Proportional vertex editing

Proportional vertex editing is mainly employed to create a flow in the shapes when working with vertices. It works only in Edit mode, and the keyboard short-cut is the O key. Proportional vertex editing is predominantly used in the creation of items such as grounds and bevels in 3D scenes. As you progress, the feature you'll be using the most is the Knife tool. Notwithstanding that, we can safely bypass proportional vertex editing in this article, since the methods and techniques employed have remained unchanged for the past couple of years.

Lighting and cameras

At the most basic level, your work in Blender will not have items that involve the use of a lamp, but will surely make use of the camera. Ideally, even the most minimal scene must have at least 3 or 4 lamps for proper rendering. The major types of lamps or lights used in Blender 2.49b are listed in Table 2.

There have been slight alterations in the mode of lamp creation in Blender. To create a lamp in the present version, place the 3D cursor at the desired location, press 'Space' and select *Lamp->Type*. You will see various options associated with lamps, as shown in Figure 3. The best way to implement lamps fully is to experiment with the options and tweak your way through things (after all, there's no fun in going by orthodox style tutorials)!

Type of Light	Purpose
Lamp	Basic Blender lamp which shines in all directions.
Area	Provides large area lighting and can be scaled.
Spot	Shines a direct angle of light.
Sun	Provides an even angle of light, regardless of the placement from objects.
Hemi	A wider light.

Table 2: Lamps / lights used in Blender 2.49b

As regards cameras, your scene is expected to have one by default, and it should suffice—unless you intend to do something extraordinary, such as creating a 3D Jackie Chan stunt simulation. However, if you do plan to have more cameras, simply use the space bar. To toggle between active cameras, press Ctrl and Numpad 0. The most recent innovation in Blender 2.5 seems to be the addition of the adjustable lens length, which you can set up as you would in a real camera. Personally, I retain a 35mm length for most of my work.

The article will surely leave you slightly confused if you've had no previous experience with Blender or any other similar 3D tool. But rest assured, things will definitely fall into perspective once you commit yourself to just a few determined efforts! The purpose here is not to give you a spoon-fed guide to computing, but instead, to acquaint you with the most recent and latest changes in this wonderful software— Blender. END

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